

THE COLD WAR

After World War II it was clear that the tank had a dominant, but not invincible, place on the battlefield. Shaped-charge warheads fired from cheap, lightweight weapons presented a major threat even to the heaviest tanks, and this prompted many manufacturers to stress mobility over armor as the best form of protection. The tanks of the Cold War adversaries first faced each other during the Korean War, but that conflict saw few tank battles, with armored vehicles being used mainly as infantry support. Likewise, both the American forces in Vietnam and the Soviet forces in Afghanistan deployed large numbers of armored vehicles, but they rarely faced enemy tanks. Indeed, the largest tank battles of the Cold War did not involve the superpowers at all. Some battles of the Indo-Pakistani

War of 1965, for instance, involved hundreds of tanks on each side.

The Israeli experience of the Six Day War of 1967 and the Yom Kippur War of 1973 spurred critical developments in tank design. High Israeli losses to antitank missiles accelerated work on new methods to protect against shaped charges, including Explosive Reactive Armor, which was developed by the Soviet Union and Israel, and British Chobham armor, made of layers of different materials. During the 1980s, a new generation of tanks incorporating this armor, and systems such as computerized fire control and thermal night sights took to the field. Many of these tanks proved themselves in the first Gulf War in 1991, where their superiority over older Soviet vehicles was clearly demonstrated.



△ Vietnamese pride

A nationalist poster celebrates the victory of Vietnam over its former colonial masters with an image showing tanks leading the country to freedom.

“Victory is no longer a truth. It is only a word to describe who is left alive in the ruins.”

LYNDON B. JOHNSON, PRESIDENT OF THE UNITED STATES

Key events

- ▷ **1945** The Soviet IS-3 Heavy Tank takes part in the Allied Victory Parade in Berlin, alarming Western observers.
- ▷ **1950** The outbreak of the Korean War generates a “tank panic” in the US, accelerating the development of new vehicles.
- ▷ **1956** Soviet tanks are involved in street fighting during the crushing of the Hungarian Revolution. Several are destroyed with improvised weapons.
- ▷ **1965** India stops a Pakistani invasion at the Battle of Asal Uttar. Pakistan loses 99 of over 250 tanks; India loses 10.



△ M48 Patton in Vietnam

Vietnamese rangers are covered by a US M48 Patton in a battle in the Cholon district of Saigon during the Vietnam War.

- ▷ **1972** Centurion AVREs demolish IRA barricades during Operation Motorman, the largest operation during the Troubles in Northern Ireland.
- ▷ **1973** On the Golan Heights, a force of just 170 Israeli Centurions stall an invasion of over 1,200 Syrian tanks.
- ▷ **1980** The American M1 Abrams enters service, the first tank to be fitted with Chobham armor.
- ▷ **1982** During the Lebanon War, the Israelis make the first use of Explosive Reactive Armor.
- ▷ **1991** At the Battle of 73 Easting, during the first Gulf War, US tanks destroy some of Iraq’s most capable forces, despite being vastly outnumbered.

◁ **A Soviet propaganda poster** depicts Stalin (left) standing over an army led by columns of invincible-seeming tanks.